

EXCEL AGENT MODE SETUP SHEET

1. Before You Turn On Agent Mode

- ☐ Raw data is in structured Excel Tables
- ☐ Column names are consistent and stable
- ☐ Aggregated totals reconcile to source data
- ☐ Weighted metrics are explicitly defined
- ☐ Baseline snapshot saved before structural edits

Fix structure before adding autonomy.

2. The Core Mental Shift

Copilot Prompt → Requests an Answer

Agent Instruction → Defines Responsibility

Copilot:

- Interactive
- Human steers
- Errors corrected immediately

Agent Mode:

- More autonomous
- Can modify model structure
- Requires explicit correctness rules

Do not stretch a prompt into instructions. Write a behavioral contract.

3. The Correctness Contract (Minimal Version)

Every serious Agent Mode setup should include:

Reconciliation

Modeled totals must tie back to source data.

Invariants

Conditions that must always hold:

- Weighted calculations remain weighted
- Percentages bounded 0–1
- Forecasts non-negative
- Row counts match defined windows

Boundary Tests

Explicit threshold cases:

Just below

At threshold

Just above

Stop Conditions

If validation fails:

→ Halt

→ Explain

→ Do not “patch” silently

4. The Agent Workflow

Every modification follows:

1. Clarify

What is the exact request?

What assumptions are required?

4. Re-Validate

Recalculate again

Confirm reconciliation + invariants

2. Validate Before Change

Recalculate

Confirm all tests PASS

5. Report

Separate structural PASS/FAIL from analysis

3. Modify

Add logic

Add validation checks for new calculations

5. Minimal Agent Instruction Skeleton

Purpose

Preserve structural integrity while extending the model.

General Rules

- All material calculations require validation.
- Totals must reconcile.
- Invariants must be checked.
- If validation fails, stop.

Workflow

Validate → Modify → Re-Validate → Report.

6. When to Use This Level of Discipline

Use governance when:

- Financial reporting
- Forecasting
- Tiered compensation
- Operational dashboards
- Models others depend on

Skip heavy governance for:

- Personal sandbox analysis
- Quick exploratory work
- Low-stakes one-off tasks